



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

LOS ANGELES' metro area has more foreign-born residents than any city but New York. Above, Fasika Abraham sits in the market side of Merkato Ethiopian Restaurant and Market last week in Los Angeles.

Will the L.A. we know survive Trump's trade war?

When Fang Chen was growing up in the wealthy city of San Marino in the 1980s, it was still a majority white community, one where locals occasionally exploded into ugly moments of racism at the arrival of new Asian residents.

Today, the community is nearly 70% Asian, with nearly half of all residents born outside the country, according to the U.S. census. And Chen, a stay-at-home mom who travels frequently to China to visit relatives, said that for years she has urged friends and family there (assuming they have the means) to consider purchasing a stately man-

Merchants across the globalized region express profound uncertainty over the economy and culture

By Jessica Garrison, Connor Sheets, Jack Flemming, Ruben Vives, Sonja Sharp and Melissa Gomez

sion on one of San Marino's graceful tree-lined streets.

But President Trump's sweeping on-again, off-again tariffs have caused her to reconsider.

"I'm not sure I can make that case anymore," she said last week, relaxing under a tree in the manicured green expanse of Lacey Park, where she had retreated, she said, to try to decompress from all the unsettling economic news. "There's a lot of anxiety among my neighbors, because so many of us have friends and relatives in the countries affected by the tariffs."

[See Globalization, A10]

AI may be an edge or an issue in job search

Employers, applicants navigate 'Wild West' of generative tools. Where to draw line?

By QUEENIE WONG

Dani Schlarmann, a recruiter, noticed something fishy about the job applicants.

Cover letters and resumes sounded identical. Candidates embellished their experience to match the job description. On top of that, engineers were caught using artificial intelligence tools to "cheat" on live coding tests.

The California resident, who works for blockchain technology company Ava Labs, vented about his frustrations with AI on social network LinkedIn. To address the issue, Ava Labs started asking some candidates to sign an agreement that they will not use AI assistance during their interviews, he said.

"We've had a few people fight us back on it and say, 'We should be able to use any tool at our disposal.' Honestly, this is not the company for you, then," said Schlarmann.

[See AI tools, A12]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

STUDENTS HEAD TO class at University High School Charter in Los Angeles. California is among 10 states refusing the Trump administration's DEI directive.

State rejects order to certify removal of DEI from schools

California educators defend diversity programs amid Trump administration's demand, threats to cut funds

By HOWARD BLUME

California on Friday defied a Trump administration order to certify that the state's 1,000 school districts have ended all diversity, equity and inclusion programs despite federal threats to cut billions of dollars in education funding if the state does not comply.

The U.S. Department of Education has given states until April 24 to collect certifications from every school district in the nation — confirming that all DEI efforts have been eliminated, as it contends such programs are a form of race-based discrimination and violate civil rights laws.

In a letter to school district superintendents Friday, the California Department of Education, or CDE, defended the legality of DEI efforts.

"There is nothing in state or federal law ... that outlaws the broad concepts of 'diversity,' 'equity,' or 'inclusion,'" wrote Chief Deputy Supt. David Schapira in the letter to

[See Education, A13]

California's farmers face tariff-driven uncertainty

Exports shrink as global markets retaliate, leaving growers anxious about the long-term effect.

By IAN JAMES

CERES, Calif. — President Trump's decision to pause punishing tariffs on most U.S. trading partners may have calmed financial markets last week, but it did little to quell anxiety in California's \$59-billion agricultural industry.

While Trump kept smaller 10% blanket tariffs on countries around the world, he has imposed much higher levies on products from Canada and China, two of the top markets for California's almonds, pistachios, oranges and other crops.

Trump increased tariffs on Chinese goods to 145%. Beijing retaliated by slapping 125% tariffs on American goods, including California nuts and dairy products.

Canada retaliated against U.S. tariffs with 25% taxes on American goods, which are already cutting into sales of California agri-

cultural products, including fresh produce and wine.

Farmers in the Central Valley say they are nervous about what might come if Trump goes ahead with the larger, so-called reciprocal tariffs after the 90-day pause.

If the upheaval persists, they fear it could spiral into long-lasting and damaging conflicts.

"It's scary," said Christine Gemperle, an almond farmer in Ceres, near Modesto. "Nobody wants to be in the center of chaos."

Bianca Kaprielian, a fourth-generation citrus farmer in Reedley and co-chief executive of Creekside Organics, said she is already seeing sales suffer.

"Across the board, everybody's going to feel it," she said.

Elsewhere in Fresno County, farmer John Diener said he hasn't yet seen effects on the sales or prices of his crops, but he's watching closely.

"People are waiting with bated breath," he said. "I think everybody in their business is concerned about what might be the outcome."

Trump has said he be-

[See Agriculture, A8]

Edison CEO says idle power line a top theory in fire

He calls the idea that dormant equipment became reenergized a 'leading hypothesis' in Eaton blaze's origin.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

The possibility that an idle, unconnected Southern California Edison transmission line somehow reenergized on Jan. 7 is "a leading hypothesis" for what started the destructive Eaton fire, Edison International Chief Executive Pedro Pizarro said Friday.

In response, Edison will take steps to harden other idle towers and lines across its network to prevent reenergizing incidents. Those measures include conducting additional field inspections, reviewing past inspections, and making changes in an internal maintenance manual that instruct crews on how to properly ground the idle equipment.

In a Friday interview with The Times, Pizarro said the actions were being taken out of "an abundance of caution." He also stressed that the company is still exploring all possibilities into what caused the fire. However, current evidence — including videos and data from the lines — suggests the possibility that the idle equipment was reenergized through a phenomenon called induction and sparked the Jan. 7 inferno.

"Induction seems to be a key thing to be looking at here because the idle line was not connected to any equipment," Pizarro said. "It had no direct source of power. It was like an extension."

[See Edison, A13]

Tariffs to exclude some electronics

U.S. exempts phones and other popular imports, setting stage for a rally in tech stocks. **NATION, A6**

Menendez duo to be resentenced

The brothers will get another chance at a path to freedom this week. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Urban planting, for a better world

Despairing at "all this bad news," a scientist transforms a grim piece of land. **WEEKEND, L6**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 73/53. **B10**

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